



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with JP

Anonymous (JP)

18th September 2018

Location: Queen's University Belfast

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Olivia Dee

Warning this interview contains details of domestic violence

JP visited the Queen's University campus on 18th September 2018 and was interviewed by Olivia Dee (OD). Prior to recording JP explained that as a teenage school leaver she took up paid employment in the laundry at *name of Good Shepherd convent redacted*. JP related her thoughts on the different types of women working in the laundry who she watched enter each day from the Good Shepherd St Mary's home. She believed that some of them had learning disabilities, whilst others had recently given birth and were then transferred into the St Mary's home from the mother and baby institution on the convent complex. Women in the latter group were often extremely emotional in the aftermath of childbirth and having had their infant baby removed from them for adoption or fostering. Sometime after she had left her work in the laundry, a neighbour took JP to the convent when her father threw her out of the family home after she revealed she was pregnant. With nowhere to go, a neighbour drove her to the Good Shepherd convent and its mother and baby home. JP explained that during a very short stay, one of the nuns repeatedly tried to convince her to have her baby adopted. She resisted this suggestion and, instead, left the convent and sought help from social services. A social worker then arranged accommodation and support for JP. It was an emotional interview, and at some places on the tape there is silence as OD and JP paused to make allowances for this. The recording includes a preamble that is not included on the transcript.

Locations, names and dates have been redacted to protect JPs anonymity and that of others who she discussed in her testimony. Redactions are indicated by ** JP's daughter's name has been anonymised as V.

OD: My name is Olivia Dee, I am a researcher on the Mother and Baby homes project at Ulster and Queen's University, we're anonymous but the date is the 18th September 2018. Could you tell me your story, start where you feel comfortable?

JP: I ... Early in *date in the 1970s redacted* I was engaged, and I was looking for employment, and I was searching about and I got the employment in the Good Shepherds *name of laundry/convent redacted*. Sister U who employed me. I went to work in the laundry in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted*, and it was [my] first experience ... They started me off in the washroom. In the washroom, B from *urban location redacted*, was the head lady, who done, who's over the laundry [a paid employee], and then there was other girls there who were in it who were not married and having children¹ ... and little girls that were kind of, what you say, slow with learning disabilities and older, older people. So, C, who was from *rural location redacted*, was a bit slow, so she was to teach me how to use the machine, you know the hand-held machine?

OD: Like an ironing machine or ...?

JP: No, a hand, it's ... you know when you used to go into the toilets there's a roller machine with loo ... Ye.

¹ They would have had their children before being relocated to the St Mary's Home to work in its laundry.

OD: Yes.

JP: So, C had to learn me how to use the machine ... But I cut my finger because there was blades in it ... so then I stayed there for a while. Then they moved me to the ... the calendar machine. The calendar machine is where two people feed the sheets into the big machine. So, the girl that was there was ... had been in it ... she was from *location in the Republic of Ireland redacted* ... we called her D and she had had a baby that ... a while ... a few ... a week or two before. So, she was teaching me how to use the machine and that's how I started off. I stayed there for a good while and but, D didn't stay too long because after she had the birth of a child, she only was there with me for a short while because she had her baby. Then she would, she come over and she showed me a photo of her, of her boyfriend, who she had the child with ... He didn't know. Lovely girl ... D, and she showed me who he was and his occupation and that was in the photo ... who he was. Then the next few days, when I'm back again, D was gone. So, they kept me on the machine there for a while, then they moved me to the big machine. It's a presser.

OD: Ok.

JP: Yep. But when I was on the calendar machine there was a girl here that you call her ... she used to work the shirts. It was like a wee dummy, and the shirts blew out. She had been in there, but she was took from a home in *location redacted* ... And she was a nice girl, I'm to find her name ...um ...

[Silence while JP looks through her notes]

She had ... I can't remember her name at the minute, she was working the machines, doing the ... she come from *location redacted*. She was in care in

location redacted and they transported her to *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted* and ... I know her second name's *redacted* ... She told me but I can't think of her first name at the minute ... I'll think about it. But the machine where she worked, there was a door that led from where the girls were in their place of work, and they used to come in that way ... Then the girls, they come in that way and that was just normal, but then one day they come in and there was a girl come in and she was by ... all huddled and shaky and nervous together, and these were the older wee women who, you know, C and the older women ... [and they included] F from *location redacted*. That was her name, but that was the name, they give yer a name² ... She was quite nervous ... that was then but then there was an older woman with them. She was an older woman, but I only knew her as G at that time, but I was friends with G's brother from when he was nineteen but I didn't know of her existence. She was a wee bit disabled. She used to run round with a gun shooting ye, we used to call G, Annie Oakley³, was her nickname because, because I ... you know what I mean ... but she, I didn't know who she was until *name of Good Shepherd convent* closed down and then, I found out who she was later, years ago, in *location redacted*. So that was it, they put me on the, the big machine, the calendar machine and I was working there for ... they put me on to ... eh ... priests' robes

OD: Ah vestments?

JP: Vestments. They done that for a good while. So, and then that was that. And then at lunchtime, this was the way it was. At lunch time the girls ... when they went out the door where that girl worked with the shirts, that was their door, they were sent that way, and our door was here [gestures to indicate location of the

² A reference to the Good Shepherds allocation of a new Christian name to girls and women in the St Mary's Home. This occurred until the early 1970s.

³ A reference to the musical *Annie Get Yer Gun* which featured Annie Oakley

door] But out this way was the laundry where the stuff went, you know, where they store ... where the sheets were going there, everything had a number on it ...

OD: Ok.

JP: ... a number that was towels, sheets, there would have been. I was doing the priests' robes, sheets for the hotels and things like that. Now...

OD: So, the hotels were using them?

JP: Oh, the hotels were using ... and the priests I was doing the robes ... and also them hand towels ... they would have been from somewhere, you know, workplaces but that time there was two ... there was the *name redacted* Hotel in *location redacted*. Don't know if that was the sheets we were doing, but they were doing the hotel's sheets and aprons. So then for, we used to go, we arrived for our tea, out this way to the, it was a room, and you got soup, watery soup, watery tea and hard ... the bread was like you could bang it up. But that's, that was for the workers, but sometimes if you seen, we had to go back and start a bit earlier and there was a door outside where there used to be a seat. Some of the women that worked with me there was H ...*surname redacted*, but her maiden name was *redacted*. She had been there, but she also had a child adopted out [of] there as well, and myself and B, and the other ...P... the lady at the washroom, and we used to go down for our tea there and that there. But some of the women would go out and sit in the seat to have a smoke. I don't smoke, and I could have because it's quite warm ... you know it's alright in the winter working that thing but very hot. It was warm when I went out. I went to have a cup of tea then I would go down, ... go down to the chapel.

OD: Hmmm.

JP: So, then I would go down, and say a prayer in the chapel, and I just took a notion. But I walked in one day and I just, I didn't know, I didn't realise what was going on really, I was naïve. I turned around and I walked in and there was a man and a woman, standing and a nun and them up at the altar where they were baptising a child and er, I didn't know but I was very naïve, you know what I mean? Didn't realise ... but the moral was when you worked in it you only knew their first name. They did ... as a worker ... they did not want you to interact with or to bother with the girls, you know what I mean? But I'm the kind of person to, you know if you're working in an environment you have to be sociable with people. It's my nature. But in my head I didn't realise what I kinda, I didn't know what kind of place it was and you may say that I'm naïve but all I knew I was going in to work in a laundry.

OD: How old were you?

JP: At the time, my daughter, that was '7*, I was born in 196*, that was 197* ...

OD: So, you were eighteen?

JP: Was I eighteen yeah? Yeah. So, I ... I couldn't believe it, but I went anyhow, and I worked, and I worked and I ... was in night a whole lot of times working in it, and my cousin (J) says to me: "You know, is there any work there?"

I says: "Well I don't think *you'll* like it but if you like J, I'll ask you ... I'll ask for you." So, J got the chance of a job. She stuck it three days, she was gone out the door. But, you see, I was used to hard work. She maybe had had an easy life. So, on the, on ... when we worked out there, there was two van drivers, one was called K and the other fella I can't remember. But sometimes if you were coming

in the road, they'll give you a lift because they lived out in the country and drop you in the road. It was decent enough, but J didn't stay. And they give you a lift. And wh ... since then K had died, he was from country, a farming fella, kept the cows. So, he was gone after that. I worked in it a good while, for a good while after that, but as I say, I ... come, I'm the oldest of five, and my mother had left us, so I was the person to look after the family at home. So, I worked a lot. But in my experience of being in there, a very cold, very ... you know what I mean, it, they didn't, there was no ... just do the work and out, they were very cold, it was a very cold environment you know.

OD: Yep.

JP: Well B and N *surname redacted*, and P she's from *location redacted* ... and H *surname redacted*, they were the ones in the main store where the goods went out to, to the hotel and that was their ...

OD: ... and they were workers, not, not...

JP: Well H, H came, H *surname redacted* she had a child adopted ...

OD: ... ok ...

JP: ...yes. P from *location redacted* was a spinster and N *surname redacted*, spinster too. Cause I know, and they all come from *location redacted*. So ... they were out there, but H was also working in *name of mother and baby home redacted*. she has also worked down in the labour ward in *name of hospital redacted*.

OD: Ok.

JP: Where when, she would have served you your tea. She was H *maiden name redacted* ... her name at the time, but H *surname redacted* now. Very good friends with Sister U. Sister U. Well Sister U was the one who employed me. She didn't have anything on me. Do you know what I mean? But as I say I worked there, I mean, so all the ladies that I remember who were there I can remember most ... most of them anyhow you know what I mean. So, P ... is dead with dementia, B in *location redacted* same story ... she was the main one in the laundry. She was there for years, she's dead. H *maiden name redacted*, H *surname redacted* now, still lives down the road from me where I live. N *surname redacted*, dementia. G *surname redacted* dead, cancer. But I often would have loved to trace D from *location in Republic of Ireland redacted* because I knew the birth of the child she had, and I knew who she had the child to. Y'know? Um, and ..., C worked in it, C was put in there too, she was in it, she was disabled girl, she was from *rural location redacted*. She lives in *urban location redacted* today and I've said the two, the van drivers, K, he ... they were country fellas, they died. And Sister U who employed me, you know, and I know that, that girl, her name was T, T *surname redacted*, I meet regularly around *location redacted* and she says: "JP, it, it was a tough life." And she told me what happened to her. She said: "I was in care in a home in *location redacted* and brought to *Good Shepherd convent".

...But the end of the day I was there and then the situation for me, why I had to leave, because my father had five [of] us, and he had a drink problem and I left, I had to leave because of my care ... at home. The reason why I went there was to get work, because the partner [JP's then boyfriend] he was working, and I wanted to get, no see we had two bank accounts and were saving to get married.

OD: So, you were engaged at eighteen?

JP: Seventeen. Because he had to ask my father's permission. Now, if you want me to carry on the second part? Right. What happened was, I was seventeen, and er, I ... yeh I was pregnant, I was, I found out I was pregnant, I didn't realise I was pregnant, so I had to tell. I was talking to my neighbour next door *name redacted* saying: "Well what am I going to do? I am terrified, I'm afraid of telling me Pa." She says: "JP you can't hide any longer, you're gonna have to tell him."

OD: How many months?

JP: Couple, I didn't go, I was too afraid, I was terrified. So, I turned round and I says: "right" one day, and ... [the] just, *neighbour redacted* - I had no mother, I had no one to talk to - she says: "Just tell him JP." So I did. All hell broke loose in the house. He went mad, called me all the names under the sun, tramps, and everything: "You've let yourself down! You've brought disgrace to our family! What have you done? Oh, you've destroyed your life!" But the roaring and shouting! In our community, we live facing, we live face to face, and ... he says: "Get out!" Excuse the language please [he said] "Get the eff out that door and don't come back, you've brought nothing but bloody shame and disgrace." And everybody in the street was listening to this. The neighbours and everything. I says; "Where am I gonna go?" I didn't know what to do. So, I went on down the road and I says 'right', there was a flat lying idle, on the hill, just round from ... and the neighbours across were called *redacted*, Mr and Mrs *redacted* ... and the whole street heard it there's no use denying it. They drove around, they are good people, driving around looking for me and he says: "What you done?", he says. "Where am I gonna go?"

He says: "JP you can't stay here love." We came down and the wife sat along with me, he says "you can't stay here."

'Why?'

He says “because you’re not a tenant, you’ll get thrown ...’ It was an empty [flat].

OD: Yeh.

JP: But ... He said: “Tell you what JP ... You worked in the Good Shepherds didn’t yeh?”

And I say “Yeah.”

‘Maybe they might help you?’

I said “Dunno.” I wasn’t fussed but he saying that, what could I do because I wouldn’t been allowed to stay ... it was a derelict, it was a house that wasn’t mine, it was derelict. So, he took me, took me out to the Good Shepherds, to the door, that was the door, we wouldn’t have used that door. Ours was a work door down the alley. I wouldn’t have been used to coming in up there. Well, the nuns, that’s the nun’s building. So, rapped the door and he says: “I hope you’re alright doll” and he left me there. She opened the door, the nun did, and I say to her: “I’ve walked here and I’m in a bit of trouble, do you think you can help me?” And I was, I was green and naïve.

OD: Yes.

JP: I didn’t. I don’t think I really connected to what was going on and what a, looking back now and seeing -

OD: Of course, but ...

JP: ... yeah I was naïve. I wasn’t wise in the world, put it that way, having no mother and things like that. So, she opened the door and she says: “Right come with me.” Soon as the door opened, she went like that, as if, I felt as if I was a bit of dirt. Do you know what I mean, it wasn’t the attitude when you working with

someone, you know, you're an, you know what I mean? She opened the door, she, she, opened the door then she locked it. She's: "Come with me", like that: sharp. Into the parlour ... she took me into the parlour: "Right hold on then till I get these keys." So, she got the keys. She walked me along this way, down a bit but there was like steps, steps down to it. And she opened it and it was a key, the door locked when you go in ... putting in the parlour ... she didn't lock the parlour door ... not ... just went to get the keys and walk down and took me down these steps into this, like a dormitory type of ... there was a door on it and she took the key and unlocked it. Now it was locked when I'm down, do you know what I mean? She says: "Just go on in there" she says and I ... I ... I said ... I never remember getting anything to eat but when I went into it. Don't know if it was the first day or the second day, but there was a lady there with a child, she come from *location redacted*, and I says, ... because the door was locked all the time, I couldn't get out. I definitely could not. I was locked in. And she turned round this woman and she's talking to me, and I said: "Where are you from?" You know just being civil. She's saying from *location redacted* and says that at that time she'd her daughter with her. She's: 'But I've been here before.'

I says "Have you?"

She says: "Yeah I have a child adopted here."

I say: "What are you ... I'm here because I'm pregnant and you ... I was thrown out of the house because I brought shame."

And she turned around and she says: "No, I'm a domestic violence."

So that she had been used for domestic violence. And this was right. So that went on and you know she was different to me. Then the nun used to come down, only the door unlocked, but I do not remember eating food. I, for the short time I was there I don't think, I couldn't eat. And she come down, the doors were open. She [the nun] comes in to me: "Well." she says, "have you made a decision yet?"

I says: "What decision?"

“Really”, she says, “I don’t think the situation you’re in that you should keep this child.”

“What?” [said JP]

She’s like: “We’ll help you then.”

I said: “I comes to you for help not to give the child up. I thought you might help me.”

“Oh”, she says, “no.”.

So that was it. This used to go on. I was there for that time ... that ... short time. She kept coming down, every time she come down, she’d keep at me, keep at me “but you’ve not ... you know, you can’t do this.” But that last time ... this was going on every time you see coming down ... it’ll be: “You’re not fit to keep a child, you know, you can’t. We’ll help you, we’ll help you. Just leave it.”

I said: “No.”

So, then the last time she come down, this was the last time, and she says to me: “Tell you what it is”, she says, ‘I’ve not ... I wanna explain this to you, you’ve no financialness. You’ve nothing of financial service to give this child. You’ve no security to give this child. You’ve nothing to give this child.’ This was the, it wasn’t Sister U, it was one of the other nuns. I says: “Right but you know what Sister, I mightn’t be able to give my child anything, but there’s one thing I can give it, love. And it don’t cost money.” So, I don’t think she liked that. But she niggled and niggled and on and on so. She’s: “Best thing is if you go to social worker and if you talk to the social worker, we can make arrangements for your child to be adopted, you know.”

OD: Still saying that?

JP: Yep. That’s right. So, I said: “Do you know what Sister, I would like to go to ...social service in *location redacted* to talk this over with them.”

She says: “Alright what are ye gonna do?”

I say: “Well I’ll go down and have a talk with the social worker.”

And then as what they were thinking at the time ... I had no intentions to go to talk with social- - well I did talk to social worker but not to give my child up. No. Because once I was out that door I wasn’t gonna go back. So, I ...

OD: ... so that’s how you left, by ...

JP: Saying I was going to talk to a social worker, because this was going on and on every you know and I did walk into ...ask the Social Services and say that I was, that I had a problem. That I was pregnant and I had been in the Good Shepherds and I didn’t want to give my child up for adoption of any sort. I didn’t want to it to happen me. And I says: “I’m on the streets, I’ve nowhere to go, I’ve nothing.” And I says: “if you can get me a place.”

Social worker rung the Housing Executive in *location redacted*, explained the situation, that I was on the streets and homeless and pregnant. And they couldn’t do nothing for me that night, the Housing Executive, but they promised the next day they would have something for me. So, there’s me on the streets again. So, when [I was] a child we lived in *street name redacted*, as a child from, and my dad used to have a pigeon shed down on the land where the man lived. He used to let him rent for ... I don’t know if it was still standing at the time, but the only thing is [I thought] I’ll have to go to the fields, stay in the field the night. So, I walked up around *street name redacted* to go into the field. It’s a shed, [and I thought to myself] you’ll have to hide in it and I’ll stay down there because ... I knew, the worry was with me [about] what they’d done with other girls, in my time knowing it. They’d send the police to arrest, to get you back.

OD: So, you were frightened they were going to physically take you back?

JP: Yep. And I, well I knew it had happened prior to other girls who went, maybe escaped. The police always brought them back. You understand? And I said no I'm not going, I'm not, so that's why, in my head, I was going to that fie-, that field, because it's a field. It's a way down the embankment ... its where I live, the flats beside it. I knew nothing would happen like, it scared me but. So up I went, and that's when I met, Lord have mercy on her, she's dead, *neighbour's name redacted*.... She says: "Where ya going JP?" I'd explained that my father had thrown me out and I was out in the Good Shepherd. She had a child many years ago, but her family had kept it within her family; she was lucky.

She's: "Where are you going?"

I said: "I have nowhere to go."

She's: "What?"

I said: "I'm gonna go down there where Da had the pigeon shed."

She's: "Right," She's says, 'you're not though.'

I says: "What?"

She's: "I'll give you a clean bed for the night."

And she took me in. She gave me a bacon sandwich. She gave me a clean bed and a bowl of soup.

[JP became emotional and found it hard to speak at times after this]

That's the only kindness I ever ...

OD: Take your time.

JP: She was good, that was very good of her. I appreciated that for the rest of my life. And still do. So, the next day, went down the centre, and they gave me the keys of *location redacted* on the *date redacted* 197*. And there I stay. I went into a flat with nothing in it. Nylon curtains, table that, had nothing, but it was

my roof. If I had to lay on the floor, I [would have] lain on it. So, there I went and I stayed but I had a bad pregnancy, because I spent a lot of time in the little hospital with toxemia, and my legs, I was very not well. So, I was in and out of the hospital the whole time towards the end of the pregnancy. What happened ... I gave birth to my daughter on *date redacted* in *hospital redacted* and funny when I was down having my child, H, I think, came in with tea. I had me own place, I wasn't on the street, I wasn't vulnerable do you know, do you understand? But she [H] did come down. She'd been there for years, she worked there for years, and she knew a lot more about that. But I did have her [baby daughter] and I kept her, and I kept all my children, and she, so if I couldn't give her anything, I couldn't bring her up. Today she, she is married, *location redacted*, and has gone back to university and is a qualified *occupational detail redacted.* So, I don't think I done too bad!

OD: No!

JP: So that said to me, things can be done, no matter how low you are, but, quite honest with me I feel ... I was lucky. One of the lucky ones.

OD: What do you think makes you lucky?

JP: That I had my child. For any critter to go through what I, I mean I, was mental torture and laughed at, that was what I was given, not physical but just, you know what I mean. But if I had a been gone into the laundry from there it would have been a different story than someone had worked in it. But I did see the difference when I went in there from working in it but I, I think I was naïve, I didn't really know what was going on there...

OD: You were eighteen.

JP: Yeah. I was not used to treating people with coldness and it was like a, an army, you know, military, you know what I mean?

OD: Yeah.

JP: That was just ... God love them all. Them girls. I feel sorry for them, you know.

OD: Can I ask you a bit about that time period you were in the ... when you went back in and they locked you ...

JP: Yeah.

OD: So how long, how long was that?

JP: I don't know that seemed, it could have been seven to ten days but I don't know. But that, that part, it seemed like forever.

OD: And, did they recognise you?

JP: No, but I made her aware that when I entered the door that I had, had previously worked there for Sister U. You know, but that didn't, they, from working and from going in that door, they were changed.

OD: So, they could separate you completely into two different ...

JP: Yeah.

OD: So, they put you in a dormitory alone?

JP: Ah, I think the first night or two, then that woman, yeah. First night yeah.

OD: Ok.

JP: It was like a, it was like a wee room and there was a black and white TV that wasn't going. There was a sink there, no cups, nothing. Just, and there were two or three beds because that woman slept in one of them and I slept in the other. But she was still there when I left. She was still there when I left.

OD: So, do, do you think it was like almost like a holding place to try and persuade you?

JP: Oh yeah. It was like, brainwashing you, coming down and mentally brainwashing you. You know you need to be a very strong person. I think what stood to me was the fact that my mother left me and I had to grow up from I was six. That's what made me stronger, having to learn how to look after ... and the work was nothing to me in the Good Shepherds, because I was used to hard work, washing blankets in the bath and washing and looking after my brothers and sisters you know, so.

OD: And so, if you had agreed to the adoption, what do you think would have happened? Would they have put you straight to work or ...

JP: I would have been back straight there, I would have been back into one of the rooms and then go out the door, in the door with the work, the girls from the home, yeah.

OD: Ok. So, clearly that was a place where they kept you ...

JP: Yep, they kept me there. That was like a home you're there till you know what I mean. They got, you know what I mean? Then moved on, you sorta agreed to do what you were gonna, adopt your child and I mean I, I mean, I don't know how, I was very lucky. The only reason I got out of there was saying I was going to go and talk to a social worker. But when I was in *name of mother and baby home redacted* there was a lady who used to come to, I remember her coming, always in a car. Whether she was social worker or not, but the same lady, I met her on the train one day, and ... we were talking about work, and I said: "I used to work in the Good Shepherd laundry." She says: "I used to, I used to go there",' she says, 'I used to take the babies.' See the girl who had the baby, would go to her house and she would, the child, the lady would have the baby ... would stay with her for a couple of days, and then the girl would go back to the laundry and then it was adopted. Do you understand? They had that ... was ... I didn't know who she was, but she didn't know at that time that I had been in it. Just saying I worked in, I said, because I recognised her face from coming there.

OD: Yeah.

JP: You know. I recognise her, and that was back in 197*. She used to land ... land there in a car all the time. I remember her coming. You know.

OD: So. Did the ... when you went to the social workers, did they try and convince you that adoption was better ...

JP: ... no they didn't, I have to say [they] were very helpful. They didn't ... nobody was persuading, you know what I mean, persuading me. All I wanted was ... off them, was help.

OD: Yes.

JP: And they did, they made a phone call to the ... Housing Executive, explained the situation. The only thing is they couldn't do nothing for me for accommodation because that was near five o'clock when I went down, you know what I mean it was all ... place closed. But one night on the street wasn't going to kill me. But thank God it didn't go that way. You know.

OD: I ... yeh ... I mean that's an incredibly brave ... would you ... would anything have persuaded you to go back home?

JP: At that time, my father had brought ... had met this lady through my sister ... and that wasn't the lady's fault, do you know what I mean? And I suppose it was only human, but no, I couldn't, but after I had the child he come up, my father come up to the house for me with *neighbour redacted* and to bring the child down, and I, you know, he ... knew he had wronged me. I just wanted to [voice breaks and JP cries briefly] just get on. Was ... what was done was done and couldn't be undone. You know.

OD: And what was your relationship with him like after?

JP: Well. it isn't ... but still bad, but the funny thing is, in the years to come, just he took bad *detail of illness redacted*, and I cared for him for seven years before he died. As also cared for my daughter ... but my conscience is clear, you know. It was ... everybody makes mistakes, but I think it's because my mother left him. He kinda, he always took it out on me. It was an abuse.

OD: As the oldest?

JP: I remember social services coming to the door one time. He beat me with a fishing rod, with shovels and that. Had a bad life too, him. But see, whatever makes you ... he's just drunk. You know.

OD: And then you went back and were a carer for seven years?

JP: Yep. And the, my doctor says: "You know JP you needn't ought to do this, we've carers and we'll look after him". But he [JP's father] says "No," he says 'I'm not taking, she'll do it.' That's was me. Have a sister, no, never dirtied her fingers. You know? ... It's just life, it's one of them, that's the way of things, when you was, that's hard times; five children. You know what I mean, drink, a drink problem, you know what I mean?

OD: Yeah.

JP: I remember even my brother, my brother *name redacted* saying: "Leave her alone!"

OD: Yes.

JP: You think he woulda give me some gratitude for all I done.

OD: Mmmm.

JP: With the children, and but once the new woman come along, it's ... you weren't used any more you know. Surplus to requirements that's what they say. Yeah.

OD: Did you have other sisters?

JP: Yes, sister *redacted*, aye, she was a sweet pet she was no ... no ... no ... I had three brothers yeah. Yeah.

OD: Did your sister go through anything similar or?

JP: No. She, she was married at sixteen.

OD: Oh wow! OK.

JP: She was but my dad gave her consent. It was ironic, she was, she could not do no wrong. The ironic thing was when he was not well, she didn't wanna know, I say: "Will you go down and make him a cup of tea?" You know. She's: "No."

OD: Wow.

JP: Well. I dunno.

OD: So, what about your daughter? Let's talk about your daughter.

JP: V. Yeah. I had V and whether or not but, I have nev ... I have to say you know she never caused me a tear, she never caused me a worry, you know what I mean. Didn't look back and think, and she got married and she got on with her life and made something of her life so I don't think I done too bad a job for the nuns saying you can't give nothing. Well, I think I done pretty good.

OD: Yeah. I think you've done pretty well ... so did you find that your relationship with your daughter was strained at all through what you'd been through or was it...

JP: No close!

OD: Closer.

JP: I'm closer to her.

OD: Further away from the other ...

JP: Further away from the other ... I have a good bond with her and she knows everything.

OD: So you, you told ...?

JP: I told her, I told her from the start, yeah.

OD: And how does she, how does she feel about it?

JP: No she doesn't say anything she just ... she knows that I was engaged and the relationship broke down and that I ended up there. She doesn't say much about it, but she knows, you know, she does.

OD: So, while, if you don't want to answer this it's fine, when you found out you were pregnant what, what happened to the fiancée?

JP: What happened was I, we were going to pre- you call them pre-marriage classes that's how far ...

OD: ... Catholic pre-marriage classes?

JP: Yep.

OD: Yep.

JP: And joint bank accounts as I told you before he was working so I wanted to work too. But we used to, we were going to meet to go to the pre-marriage class so I'll ... I went for a drink to the thing, it was. And he turned round and we sit and talking. My cousin had told him something – lies - and he says to me: “*Name of cousin redacted* told me this, you know?” “Yep.”, I says, “well do you believe her?”

He says: “I don't know what to believe.”

I said: “Look do you believe her?”

“I don't know.”

I said: “Well that's enough for me” and up I got and walked away.

OD: And did you know you were pregnant?

JP: No, no I [don't] think so.

OD: Ok.

JP: Wouldn't have made any difference because if someone tells lies and they believe that person is lying, what kind of relationship would you have? There's no trust, there's no relationship is there?

OD: Agreed.

JP: So, walked away.

OD: So strong to...

JP: Yeah.

OD: At, at seventeen/eighteen to know that ... wow.

JP: Yep, yeah. I had to grow up very quick.

OD: Yeah, I'm very...

JP: Yes, from six years of age, to start washing and cleaning ...

OD: Yeah.

JP: You wouldn't think of asking a wee child to do that would you?

OD: No! I mean, definitely not.

JP: No.

OD: Wow ... well I think that's amazing. Are you ok if I keep asking?

JP: Yes, go ahead yeah.

OD: So, you mentioned obviously you were Catholic, and that's obviously perhaps why your father reacted so badly?

JP: Oh yeah.

OD: What was the role of religion when you were in the ... were you forced to go to any kind of prayers or ...?

JP: No. You didn't go to Mass, no, what it was if you want, what I done was went down to say my prayers.

OD: Yeah.

JP: I'm a Catholic in a way, you know. I would a went in and say my prayers but that was when I was working in it [when JP was a paid employee of the laundry].

OD: That's when you were working, yeah.

JP: I would be a totally different situation maybe if I had to be staying.

OD: But because you were in that room and you couldn't get out.

JP: Yeh, no that didn't ...

OD: And so again, please don't feel you have to answer I was just wondering has this affected your relationship with religion at all?

JP: Well, I still believe in God, but for what they've done, nuns and that, has I never ... I be quite honest with you. I had lovely nuns when I went to school. I had no uniform and they put them on my back.

OD: Mmmm.

JP: But that other sister, the Good Shepherds' Order, took me, now its ... no.

OD: And so do you, do you still feel like ...

JP: I still say my prayers, and I will go to Mass and that there but it's just this, I don't know I think, I wouldn't practice as much as I would [when younger]. I wouldn't go to Mass every Sunday. I will go to Mass when I wanna go to Mass, go to funerals, take my sacrament. But, no. It's just, as I say not all nuns and priests are like that, I had good help you know.

OD: Of course and I think.

JP: That's the problem!

OD: Yeah.

JP: It's like you and me sitting here. There's a bad apple in every par ... in our walk of life as well as, yeah I understand that.

OD: Absolutely. And, and sorry I am just wanting to make sure I get a full picture of ... so you don't think you were given food or you don't think you could eat?

JP: I was never offered food, I don't remember food offered, and to be quite honest with you I was that ... I wouldn't have been able to eat it. I was that distraught.

OD: And if you were going, if you were going to have toxaemia and all kinds of complications...

JP: Well yeah.

OD: Did you have morning sickness and things like that?

JP: Yeah. At the beginning I was very, very sick.

OD: And did you have any, I think you've already answered this but was there any sense of sympathy or making sure that you and the baby were ok while you were in those ...

JP: No. No. I was just took in, walked down a corridor and the door closed on me. No, I didn't get, nobody never said 'y'alright?' No one said no...

OD: No one checked you?

JP: No.

OD: No one offered a doctor?

JP: No, definitely not, no. [pause] Because if they did, I'd say. This ... you know what I was treated as if I'd committed a crime.

OD: Yeah ... it sounds like a prisoner.

JP: Yeah prison and ... yeah that's what's like.

OD: And so, I mean, a lot, a lot of what we're trying to understand is like ... that daily life in the laundry ... but it sounds like you have this very interesting perspective because you were choosing to work in the laundry and then the second half you, you were locked away from that ...

JP: I've seen it. I've seen both sides of the fence as they say.

OD: And that must have been really difficult?

JP: Yeah.

OD: Because you went in ... even just the idea that you went in through a different door.

...

JP: Yeah.

OD: ... sort of highlights the difference in treatment.

JP: And the girls, the way the girls were when we were going out, we were going this way and the poor girls where T ... there was ... where T worked at the shirt machine they were like herd, like a herd of cows and when they were coming in, they were coming in like that, herded together, and you could see their face, you know.

OD: And could you, could you talk to anyone when you were working or was it silent?

JP: No youse ... they didn't, so you weren't really allowed to talk really, but see with D learning me how to use the machine you could talk. But you weren't allowed to ... C was the same too, she would, I would [see] her in *location where JP lives now* regular and [C] they gave them wages, something very little⁴ ...

OD: The girls?

JP: Yes, some of them yes.

OD: ... She's put in there because she's a bit disabled, you know, she's out in the community now, not far from where I live.

OD: So, what about, so do you think there was difference between, so obviously you were paid and the other women who were *working* were paid ...

JP: Not very much, just.

OD: Just enough?

JP: Just enough, two pounds or something.

OD: A week or?

⁴ A reference to the small allowances paid to the women living in the St Mary's Home and working in its laundry. These payments began in the early 1970s.

JP: Dunno, it wasn't very much. Two pounds C said, you know what I mean. But she said they weren't bad to her, but you know what I mean obviously she [was] still locked in [the St Mary's Home within the convent].

OD: Do you think there was a difference in treatment between those who were there because of mental or physical disability, and those who were there because they were unmarried mothers?

JP: Yes.

OD: Yeah.

JP: Definitely. I could see that C was a girl with disabilities, slow learning that, disabled. But the girls who were pregnant [were] very nervous.

OD: Yeah.

JP: Not allowed to talk, don't ... you don't know you're not allowed to tell anybody your name, well D, I don't know if that is her name, D from *location in Republic of Ireland*. I'd love to trace her. D, and that's the only reason I, and she showed me her boyfriend's photo, who he was and what he worked. He didn't know she was in there, but that was the only way I got that wee bit of information.

OD: He didn't know she was there?

JP: No. Her boyfriend didn't know she was there, no.

OD: Where did he think she was?

JP: Dunno ... she showed me his photograph, the photo of where he worked, and she had a wee, a wee, a wee boy.

OD: And what happened to the boy?

JP: Away; he was took. Adopted, she told me. She told me, she told me, but then two days later she was gone. See, they took them from wherever they come from, D was from *location in Republic of Ireland redacted*, she told me she was from *location in Republic of Ireland redacted*, and they would take them back either to their [family] home, or to a [institutional] home in *location in Republic of Ireland* where've come from ... I mean from my time there, of contact, and that poor girl F from *location redacted*, was very nervous. She's like a girl, very afraid, a bit sick, I didn't know what was wrong with her. But I don't know if she had give birth or not long but she was very nervous.

OD: And how pregnant were these women, were they a sort of fairly early on or were they working even while they were ...

JP: Some of them, I think that girl [F] from *location redacted*, I think she already had the baby and she was very nervous.

OD: Right ... And she was working after the ...

JP: Yeah ... and I'm sure D was after having, she had give birth and was brought back there.

OD: Yeah.

JP: To ... you know you were made service, you were in service before you had the baby, and you were in service after you had the baby, until you were transferred back to A or B or went home. Some people didn't go home, some people stayed there, you know?

OD: And was it, it must have been very emotional in that room, if, you know, after someone had given birth.

JP: You know for a young girl, that young girl that I seen as in an awful state. You know, she was like shaking and nervous, you know you could see fear. I didn't, I, I be quite honest with you, I didn't know how bad it was till I seen the other side of the fence. The only thing was you weren't allowed, they didn't allow you to interact ... you know what I mean? You know. Like they were, they didn't exist. And how do you not speak to someone, you know?

OD: Yeah.

JP: You can't do that.

OD: What do you think would have happened if you hadn't gone to the social workers?

JP: Well.

OD: Do you think the pressure would have mounted? Would you have been asked to ...

JP: It would have mounted but my mind was made up? You know that I wasn't giving my child up, I don't know hindsight maybe if the people that were there

like *names of neighbours redacted*, social services and the Housing Executive, God knows what would have happened. I may have gone into hiding, what ... you had to be hiding. They would have probably rearrested and took me in. Which they did before, but I still don't think ... If I had to give my daughter up for adoption it would have killed me.

OD: Yeah.

JP: As a person, I don't think I could live with it.

OD: Which is fair enough.

JP: Yeah.

OD: I think the thing that sounds most difficult is that psychological pressure they seem to have placed on you which was ...

JP: Yeah, I live with that every day of my life.

OD: Yeah.

JP: But the one good thing is I kept my child.

OD: And I hope you can see that, you know, that was proved wrong [the argument that JP could not raise her baby] by what your daughter's done.

JP: Oh yeah.

OD: But I can understand that must have been very ...

JP: Yeah.

OD: Did you, did you ... I think you already mentioned one, but did you stay in contact with a lot of these women for a long time afterwards?

JP: No, um.

OD: Was it too difficult because I suppose they were going to different-

JP: No, um, what happened was with *name of mother and baby home redacted* at that time, that was 197*, 197*, [that] I had my daughter. Later on *name of mother and baby home redacted* closed down ...

OD: Yeah.

JP: Good Shepherds, well B, her with the washing machine, she lived in *location redacted*. Her and, her sister, I would have known, because I would have passed that way. G, when G left *name of mother and baby home redacted* G, when it closed down. She [was] originally from *location redacted* [and], her father was dying. Poor G went back to her family, G *surname redacted*. She's kind of on, *location redacted.* H had married a ... and she lives, she would know a lot more than anything, but she lives down *location redacted*. She would have remained in contact with Sister U, when she went back, Sister U went back to the South of Ireland to a convent. She died, she's died since, Sister U. Her and H woulda kept in contact. And B, I had seen her at the bus stop. She's dead. She'd dementia. The other, now there was a Z from *location redacted* used to work in the row with me; also dead. There's a lot has passed.

OD: I suppose that's because you were so young when you were there.

JP: Well T is still, T from *location redacted*, that was transferred from the [children's] home, she lives in the country, she meets me in *location redacted* and she'd say to me: "That was a bad place JP." And I wouldn't go, I wouldn't bring it up all the time but I happened to ask her : "T what's your second name?" And she said "... a bad place." But she lives away in the country, she never married and I don't know if she had children. I don't think so, she was just brought from the home as a child she told me, to *Good Shepherd convent*.

OD: Wow, yeah. And, has it, would you say, impacted your ability to kind of make friends, or have boyfriends or ...? I mean, were you ever married?

JP: Married; didn't last. Bad relationships, abuse and violence. It's just cycles of abuse, violence and that ...Twenty-three years I was very happy, twenty, with someone but they had a problem and it ended. I'm on my own fourteen years and I'm happy. It does affect your life. You know it does affect it.

OD: And do you think, I mean obviously built into that would be the relationship with your father and that, difficult childhood ...

JP: Yeah and my mother and that there, and funnily enough she come back too. She left us, and got her, she came back got her a flat, she was on, came home from *overseas location* after so many years. Drink abuse. Got her a place, I took her in, got her a place. Couldn't tell my father, and she got a flat ... took ... still have a drink, and I had to go down and I went to the hospital with her and she says: "Can I come back to you, after?"

I said: "Yeah that's right come back, yeah", and I stayed with her [slightly broken dialogue due to tears] till she died. And I held her hand, because, eh,

OD: You have lots of forgiveness.

JP: Dignity, is, a bit of dignity in dying, means a lot.

OD: I'm sure it was a huge comfort for her.

JP: Yep. She says: "Where's JP?"

I say: "Here."

And I held her hand until she died and my brothers come up and that was it ... yeah. Some people wouldn't have forgiven my father, or my mother, but I've made my mistakes, everybody makes mistakes.

OD: And do you, do you think, is that a sign of being a good Catholic, that kind of forgiveness, or is it something different, just being a person.

JP: No. Just being a, it's not a Catholic, I would say it's just a caring person ... yeah.

OD: Yeah ... that's really obvious.

JP: Sorry I'm crying love ...

OD: I ... I will wait as long as you need, it's completely fine.

JP: No, go ahead, you're alright.

OD: So, did you have any other children?

JP: Yes.

OD: How many?

JP: Three. Three girls and one boy.

OD: In addition to

JP: No that's *V, X, W, Y* That's it [her four children].

OD: And are you, do you feel you can be honest with them about what happened?
Or do you just save that for V?

JP: Well V knows what happened, Y kind of knows, I just, I wouldn't, until the ... that thing, the paper, (a media report featuring JP's under a pseudonym) the story at that time, it was actually the reason why that come to the paper. [JP explains details of being approached by a researcher investigating the Good Shepherd convent where she had worked and gone when pregnant]. I had to explain, *researcher's name redacted* had approached one of my brothers, and ... I passed it every day on the bus, and I said: "Someday I'd love to go back in there, just to stand..." Something wanted me to put closure and [then] along comes *name of researcher* to ask. *Researcher* had heard that I had been in it, through my brother's brother and asked me and I took *researcher* through everywhere, where it was and explained and you know. The *researcher* says: "You know, when you work in it and then you've been in it, how would you not know it?" But *researcher* was searching for bodies, but I could not give her any information to that, but it was like putting a ghost to rest.

OD: Yeah, so you felt better afterwards?

JP: Yeah.

OD: That's really interesting.

JP: But, in, in through that door, the eeriness, you had to walk, it's all gone now you walked through it but the smell, it's just like death. That's, it was like a death house, yep. But I wanted to put to rest you know what I mean? ... and true, and I said a prayer in the chapel.

OD: Yeah.

JP: Yeah.

OD: Like you used to when you were...?

JP: Yeah, see,

OD: That's an interesting kind of ... full ...

JP: Yeah finished it off.

OD: Wow ... OK, perfect. I just have a couple of, more questions post ... and then we can finish. And if you are needing to stop at any time just ...

JP: No you're alright, I'll just throw water on my face when we're downstairs.

OD: How do you feel about Northern Ireland, and the Northern Irish state and their ... the way, do you have any feelings towards the people, the government, the state who allowed this to happen or the way, or do you feel that the ...

JP: Well I think it should, it shoulda, you shoulda took maybe more interest what was going on in these places, that these women were suffering the abuse and violence and mental torture. You know, these women were providing a service, I know maybe we, you know, they were providing a service because we were pregnant, or any victim or older people, but the end of the day they should have looked up into what was going on in them places.

OD: So, you feel there's, there should have been more in terms of inspections, or ...

JP: Yep.

OD: and did you ever see any inspections or ...

JP: Never, never when I was there. Never.

OD: So, they were kind of left to get on with ...

JP: ... the nuns ruled and that was just it. It was the Catholic thing and that was it the same with the priests, Christian brothers and the nuns, just not all, as I say not all Orders. As I say the Mercy nuns couldn't have been any better to me when I was a child.

OD: Yeah.

JP: You know?

OD: So, you feel that the Good Shepherd ...

JP: Had a very cold regime, cold regime yeah. They were left to do what they wanted to do.

OD: And do you have any experiences, many opportunities to talk about your experience? Do people ask you, do people know, do your friend's know that your ...

JP: No. Not, only my family would have known, but with H *surname redacted* living down the bottom street and her being in it, she knows. Or with T. Not too many knows. Actually, when I actually done the, the *newspaper interview*, I actually used my other name, *redacted*, that's my name, *redacted*. At the time when I was in the Good Shepherds my name was *redacted*, since [then], I'm [known as] *redacted*.

OD: And do you feel that it's too difficult to tell people, or people don't want to know or do you have any emotions connected with the story that makes it difficult?

JP: Sometimes over my life I would start crying. Alone. I don't know, I don't tell anybody I just get on with it. It's happened, I can't undo it, but I come out of it better than a lot of people and that's, I have to say...

OD: Do you take a lot of strength from being a mother?

JP: Yeah.

OD: Yeah. And I guess coming back from people telling you that you can't do it, to be so successful at it. Yeah.

JP: Well as I say, you know, I don't tell them about it, it's not, even I didn't come forward give my name you know but ...

OD: Who you think is responsible for what happened to you?

JP: The nuns. Well, first of all my mistake becoming pregnant, my father, the nuns, how I was treated, and the government for harsh regime as that place.

OD: So, you still blame yourself to a certain extent?

JP: Yes.

OD: Why do you think there was such a culture of shame around pregnancies, why was it so ...?

JP: You were looked, in the Catholic religion, you were looked on a fallen woman, or in some cases prostitute you used to say, and you brought disgrace onto your family. You, you were like, what would you say, banished. That's what I was: banished. From the house, banished from the family and say you brought disgrace. But everybody can make a mistake, none of us are perfect.

OD: Wow. ... Is there anything else you'd like to add or anything you want to touch upon or anything you want to be recorded for this?

JP: Well, I have to say, I don't regret a minute of keeping my child, and I'm proud of the way she's turned out, so at the end of the day, I hadn't got money, I hadn't got security, but I did have love.

OD: Thank you. Thank you very much. I'm going to stop the recording there.

[Interview ends]